



# ShabbaTTogether

## Five Ways to Create an Inclusive Environment for Kids at Shul

As a group leader, the children are looking to you for cues on how to treat each other, and what behaviors you value. The informal learning environment that takes place in a Shabbat Kids' Program can be a powerful tool for shaping children's character and perspectives.

The following five techniques are tools you can use as appropriate for your group, and are most commonly used with preschool through elementary school aged children.

### 1. Shabbat Buddy System

Encourage participants to look out for another by matching up children to be buddies. Buddies make sure that their buddy gets a turn, is not left to play by him or herself, and otherwise look out for each other. Give positive feedback when you see a buddy looking out for another.

You can give the kids visuals to remind them with whom they are matched. You can give them matching color bracelets, tags on a necklace, or inexpensive necklaces of different colors.

[Click here for a link to inexpensive necklaces of different colors.](#)

### 2. Inclusive Language

#### a. I notice

Model caring behavior by verbally noticing if a child looks upset or unhappy, and then helping the child. "I notice you look sad. Is something the matter?" "Rachel is upset because he wants to play with the toy. How can we help him?"

Verbally notice behaviors that you want to reinforce. For example, "I noticed Sam helped Rivka get up after she fell. Sam, you did a big mitzvah!"

#### b. I expect

Use the words expected and unexpected in place of appropriate and inappropriate. For example, "That was unexpected! I expect everyone to be sitting in a circle." "I expect everyone in our group to help each other."

**c. Our group is....**

Use the word “group” often to build a sense of belonging for all participants. For example, “Look who is in our group today!” “I love how everyone in the group is waiting so patiently for a snack!” “What is our group plan?”

**d. Body Language**

Most of what we communicate is through our body language. Be aware of how you can make everyone feel welcome and included through nonverbal means. For example, notice who you are facing, and use gestures and facial expressions to include specific children in your communications even when you may be addressing the group or another individual. A genuine smile is also a powerful tool of inclusion.

### 3. Acknowledgements

Set aside a time each week for children to acknowledge each other’s good deeds. This group building exercise can be a great end of program routine.

Three alternate ways to run this activity:

- a. **Ball Play** Sit in a circle. One person is holding a ball, and says something positive about another person. Then, he or she throws the ball to that person, and it is that person’s turn. Repeat until everyone in the group has had something positive said about them, and has said something positive about someone else.
- b. **Paper Strips** You can have a bag with strips of papers with compliments such as “You shared today” “You smiled at me”. Children can take turns picking a piece of paper from the bag, and finding someone to whom it applies. [Click here for a printable page of compliments.](#)
- c. **Teacher Led** The teacher can say the compliments. He or she can say, “There was one child who \_\_\_\_\_ and he has \_\_\_\_\_ color hair.” Slowly have kids guess who is the one being complimented by giving more and more clues.

### 4. Transitions

In addition to a [visual schedule](#), transition reminders help children keep up with the group plan. Some children may need more time to prepare to complete an activity or to be ready to move to a new activity. Prepare children for new activities by giving them a heads up several minutes before finishing an activity. This could be done with a song such as a chant, “five more minutes, and it’s \_\_\_\_\_ time.” A timer can also be used - on Shabbos, a sand or a liquid based timer is permissible. [Click here for a timer that doubles as a sensory toy.](#)

### 5. Expectations

It’s a fun Shabbat Program - you don’t want a bunch of rules. Still, children need to know what’s expected from them. While many children understand what’s expected without explicit instructions, some children need to be specifically told what’s expected. They will not just pick it up from observation.

Explicitly tell your group what’s expected. For example, if you take your children’s group into shul, review what’s expected before they go. This may include staying with the group, using a whisper, and waiting quietly, perhaps using a fidget or a book to keep busy, while the congregation sings.